

Mobilising worker support for Just Transition policies: Testing the 'Union Effect'

Proposal for a research collaboration

In a nutshell

This project investigates what makes Just Transition strategies credible, fair, and politically sustainable in their eyes of workers currently employed in high-emission industries.

Through a **large-scale experimental survey** in France, Germany, and Poland, we seek to better comprehend **which policy instruments** (e.g., financial support, retraining, job guarantees, or community investment) most effectively build trust and consent. In addition, our study assesses **how trade union positions affect worker support** for climate measures.

To ensure the results reflect the realities of those most affected, we are recruiting a **representative sample of 1,500 workers** in sectors such as mining, automotive, and aviation. By helping distribute the survey, partners play a central role in building a **knowledge base grounded in worker experience**. These insights will ultimately inform more effective communication, negotiation, and policy design across varied national and local contexts.

This note outlines how a collaboration could help us reach a diverse participant base, while offering you **insights to support worker engagement and policy positioning in the green transition**.

Labour in Transition

As the EU accelerates its climate agenda under frameworks like the European Green Deal, Fit for 55, and the Just Transition Mechanism, it has become clear that the **political sustainability of decarbonisation policies hinges on more than their environmental rationale**.

The Just Transition agenda, initiated by the international labour movement and later championed by EU institutions, recognises these risks. The EU recently set to mobilise over €100 billion via the **Just Transition Fund and the Social Climate Fund** to support carbon-intensive regions and ease energy and transport costs for households and small businesses during the green transition.

The EU just transition support today is directed toward key industrial regions such as Eastern Wielkopolska in Poland, Lusatia in Germany, and parts of Grand Est and Hauts-de-France in France—

territories where climate policy meets longstanding economic dependency on coal, heavy industry, or automotive manufacturing.

Today, we strive to know more about the **effectiveness of these tools** in securing lasting political support among workers most at risk of job loss and communities facing long-term economic restructuring. Chief among them is the question of **how these policies can better reflect and respond to the lived realities of those most exposed** to the social consequences of the green transition.

Research objectives

This project focuses on workers in industries that are most likely to be affected by climate policies—such as those in coal, oil, gas, and other high-emission sectors. These workers often face difficult trade-offs between job security and climate goals.

In this study, we ask: **When are workers willing to support climate measures that may put their current jobs at risk? How does the position taken by trade unions shape those views?**

The first aim of this study is to understand how different kinds of Just Transition policies influence worker support. To do this, we focus on:

- Compensation-focused approaches that offer **targeted support to affected workers** (e.g. lump-sum payments, early retirement); and
- Community-focused approaches that invest in public services to strengthen **long-term rejuvenation** of affected regions.

Our second aim is to explore the role of unions and other worker organisations in shaping how these policies are received. We look at **how the credibility and visibility of union support can build trust in climate-related reforms**. Ultimately, we aim to identify what makes just transition policies both fair and politically viable from a worker's perspective.

Empirical contribution

By conducting a **large-scale survey experiment with workers in France, Germany, and Poland**, this project simulates realistic climate transition scenarios and tests which types of support measures are most effective in building worker consent for decarbonisation.

Participants are asked to choose between different Just Transition policy packages, each combining key elements such as: **Financial compensation** (e.g. severance payments, monthly income bridges); **Job guarantees** or personalised job support; **Retraining opportunities**, from basic to advanced upskilling;

and **community investments** in areas like public infrastructure, green industries, or welfare services.

These features are based on a comprehensive review of Just Transition agreements across the EU, grounding our scenarios in **real-world policy dilemmas already faced by workers and unions**—from Spain’s coal deal to severance schemes in Poland and transition companies in Germany.

This study further assesses whether the active involvement of trusted intermediaries like trade unions can help **reframe decarbonisation not as a threat, but as a catalyst for individual security, local revitalisation, and longer-term development**. Our vignette experiment assesses whether union support increases trust in envisaged plans, encourages worker participation in shaping the transition, and ultimately contribute to their realignment behind climate action.

Methods and data

To ensure that our results reflect the actual concerns of those most affected, we are recruiting a **representative sample of 1,500 workers in manufacturing sectors like mining, automotive, and aviation**. The survey will be distributed in collaboration with trade union associations and human resources departments of targeted firms.

By using these structured and robust methods, we go beyond opinion polling to understand how workers actually weigh trade-offs and whether union positions affect these choices. This survey will provide evidence-based insights to key questions:

- What do workers expect from a fair transition?
- How do different types of social policy instruments shape consent to climate action?
- What role do worker associations play in reshaping how climate policies are perceived?

Ultimately, our findings seek to support the design of more equitable, and politically viable Just Transition strategies, while offering practical tools for unions and employers to **anticipate challenges and strengthen worker engagement in different national and local contexts**.

Your role

By helping circulate the questionnaire among your members or employees, partners will help **gather a more representative and credible evidence base**, capturing the voices of those most directly affected by climate policies.

Unions and worker organisations are often the first to understand emerging concerns on the ground.

More than just a distribution channel, **your involvement will further bring trust and legitimacy to this research**, while demonstrating proactive leadership in anticipating necessary climate action.

Your contribution will finally help us deliver **insights that can inform collective bargaining, policy advocacy, and the design of transition plans rooted in what workers actually want and need**.

Output & dissemination

To ensure the results are both useful and actionable for our partners, we propose several forms of tailored dissemination:

- Project partners will first receive **early access to survey findings and a customised summary highlighting relevant insights** to their organisations. We will also be happy to organise private meetings to discuss the policy implications of the results.
- If of interest, further dissemination tools may be considered. This may take the form of a **policy brief, helping translate the findings into proposals for reform at EU level**. Main findings may also be presented at **workshops or conferences** organised by your organisation, supporting wider debate and outreach efforts around Just Transition policies in the EU.

Project partners

This project is currently supported by our home institutions, the **École Polytechnique Fédérale de Lausanne (EPFL) and the Freie Universität Berlin**. Partnership with our alma mater institution, the European University Institute (EUI), has been secured. The survey design has been submitted to the EPFL’s Institutional Review Board (IRB) to ensure full ethical compliance.

To ensure the research is policy-relevant and widely disseminated, we are engaging with a range of **institutional partners and expert organisations**. These include units within the European Commission, the Committee of the Regions.

Interest for the dissemination of the survey and its results is also explored with **Brussels-based think tanks** such as the European Policy Centre (EPC) and the European Trade Union Institute (ETUI).

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